

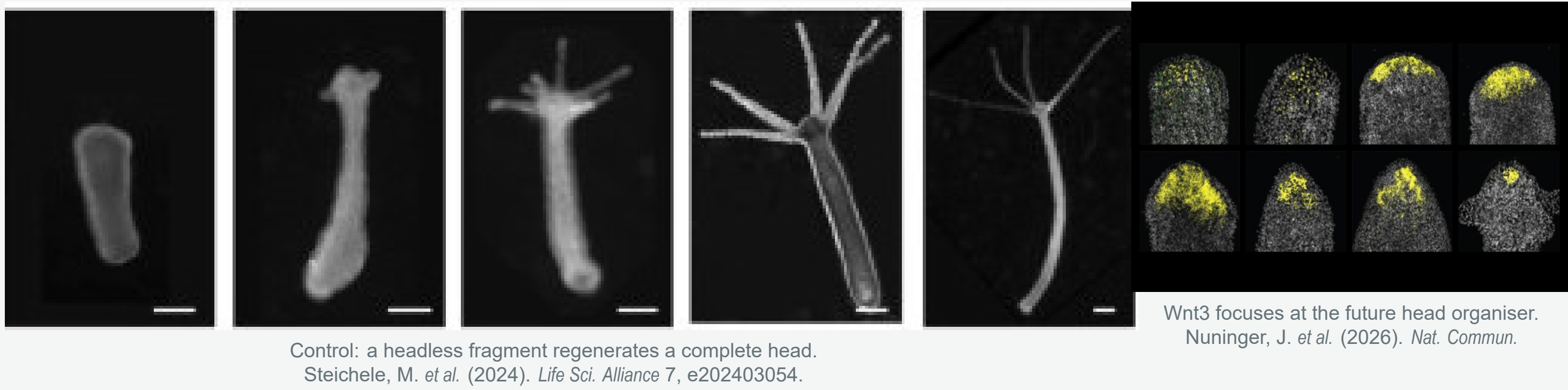
Pattern Formation and Positional Memory in Hydra Regeneration Models

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1 Motivation

1.1 Hydra as a patterning problem



2 What the activator–inhibitor model already does

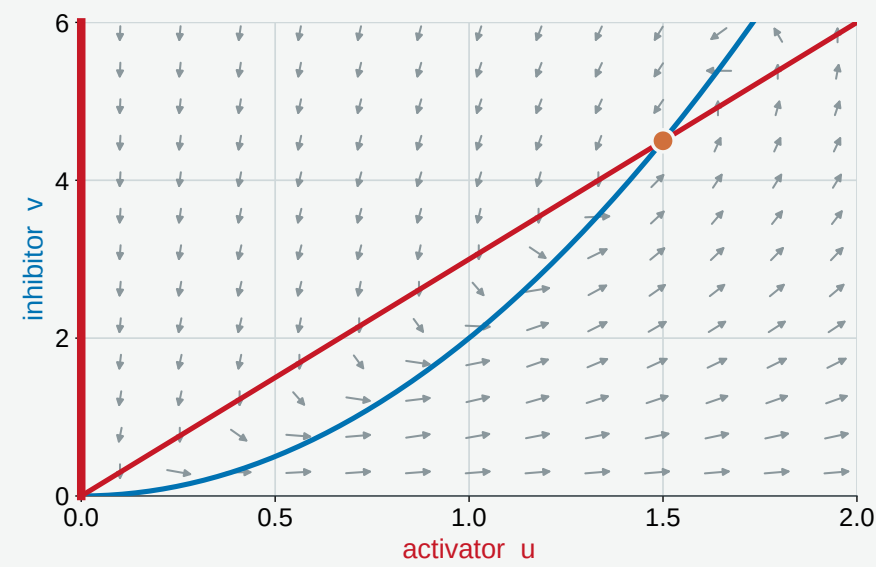
2.1 Production terms change the phase portrait

$$\begin{aligned}\partial_t u &= D_u \Delta u + \frac{au^2 + q_u}{v} - \mu_u u + p_u, \\ \partial_t v &= D_v \Delta v + bu^2 - \mu_v v + p_v,\end{aligned}\quad x \in [0, L], \quad t \geq 0$$

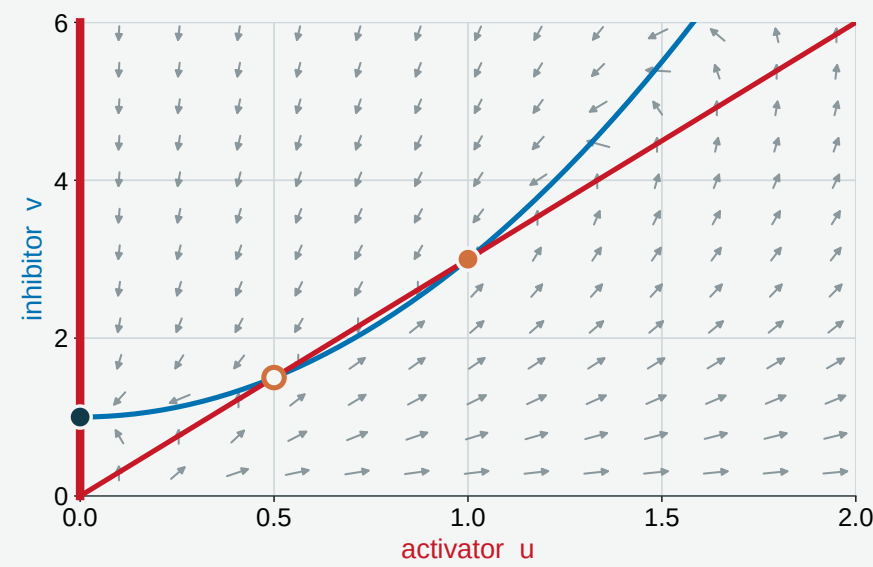
- u : activator, short-range and self-enhancing,
- v : inhibitor, long-range, produced by u .
- p_v : basal inhibitor production,
- p_u : external activator input,
- q_u : activator input under inhibitor regulation.

Nullclines

— u -nullcline — v -nullcline ● stable rest ○ unstable threshold ● active state (Turing candidate)



1 steady state ($p_v = p_u = q_u = 0$)
no resting state: an arbitrary perturbation leads to a pattern.



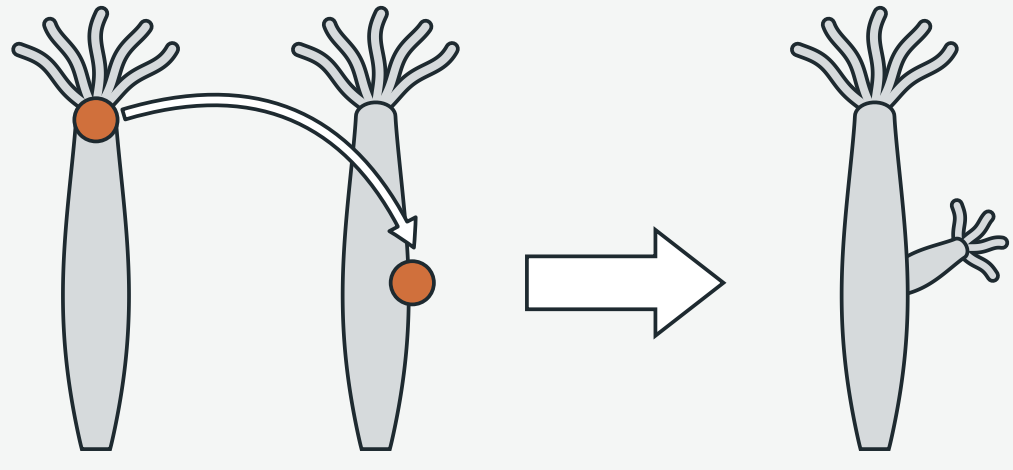
3 steady states ($p_v > 0$)
small perturbations vanish back to the rest state $u = 0$.

2.2 Inhibitor production is essential

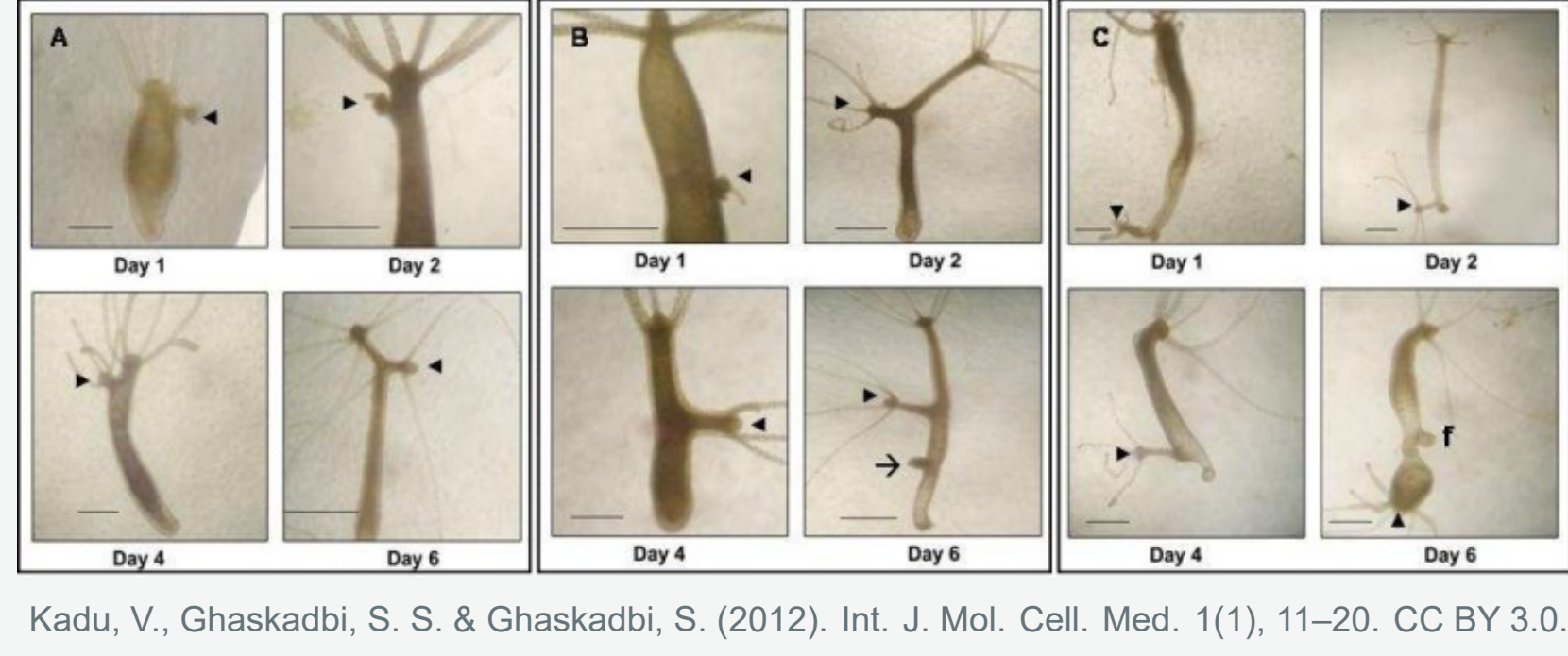
$p_v = 0$: Only one steady state, which can be Turing unstable. Any perturbation forms a pattern. $p_v > 0$: A stable rest state, an activation threshold and a pattern-forming state.

For everything that follows it is essential to have more than one steady state.

2.5 Grafts: the model chooses the position

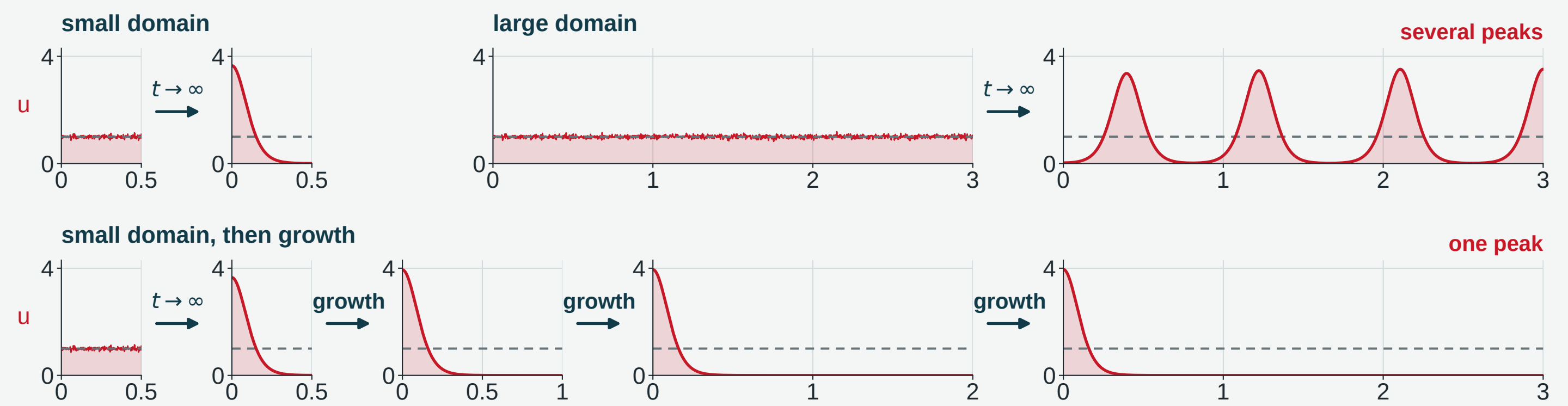


1.2 Head grafting



Kadu, V., Ghaskadbi, S. S. & Ghaskadbi, S. (2012). Int. J. Mol. Cell. Med. 1(1), 11–20. CC BY 3.0.

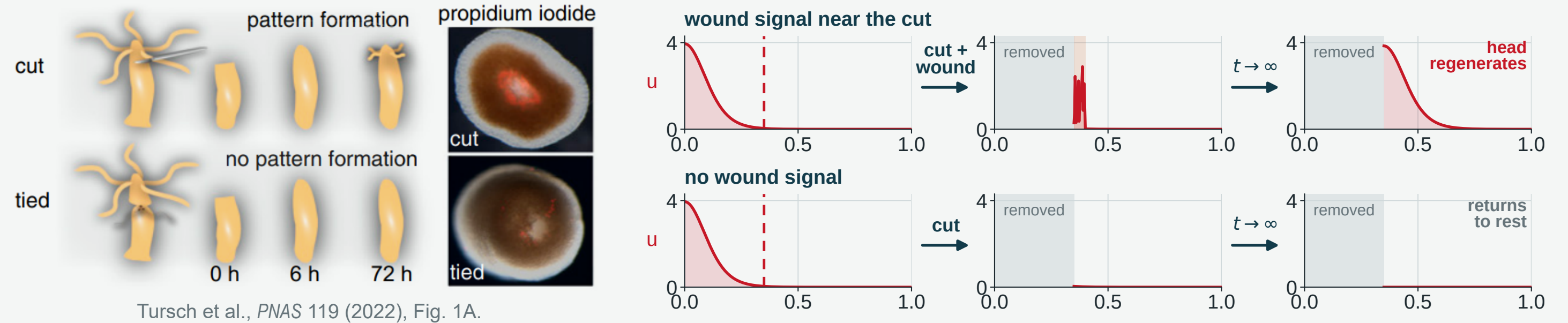
2.3 Pattern selection depends on history



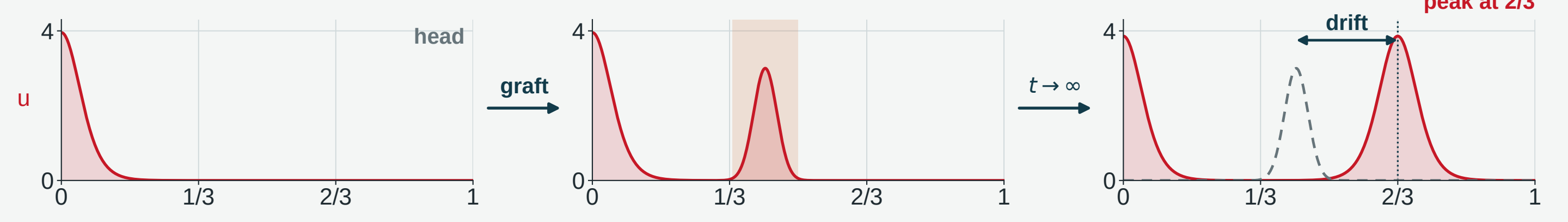
Starting near the diffusion-unstable state E_+ , a small domain forms one peak and a large domain several. Growing the small domain to the same large size keeps a single peak.

2.4 Regeneration needs a wound

Removing the head by cutting triggers regeneration. Removing it by ligation, without a wound, does not.



Bistability is essential. With a single steady state regeneration always occurs. With three steady states the system is bistable, the cut tissue returns to rest and only a large perturbation from the wound brings back a pattern. Biologically, this perturbation is the wound response. Injury triggers Ca^{2+} and ROS signalling, which activates MAPKs and up-regulates Wnt3 at every cut, independent of its position (Tursch et al., 2022).

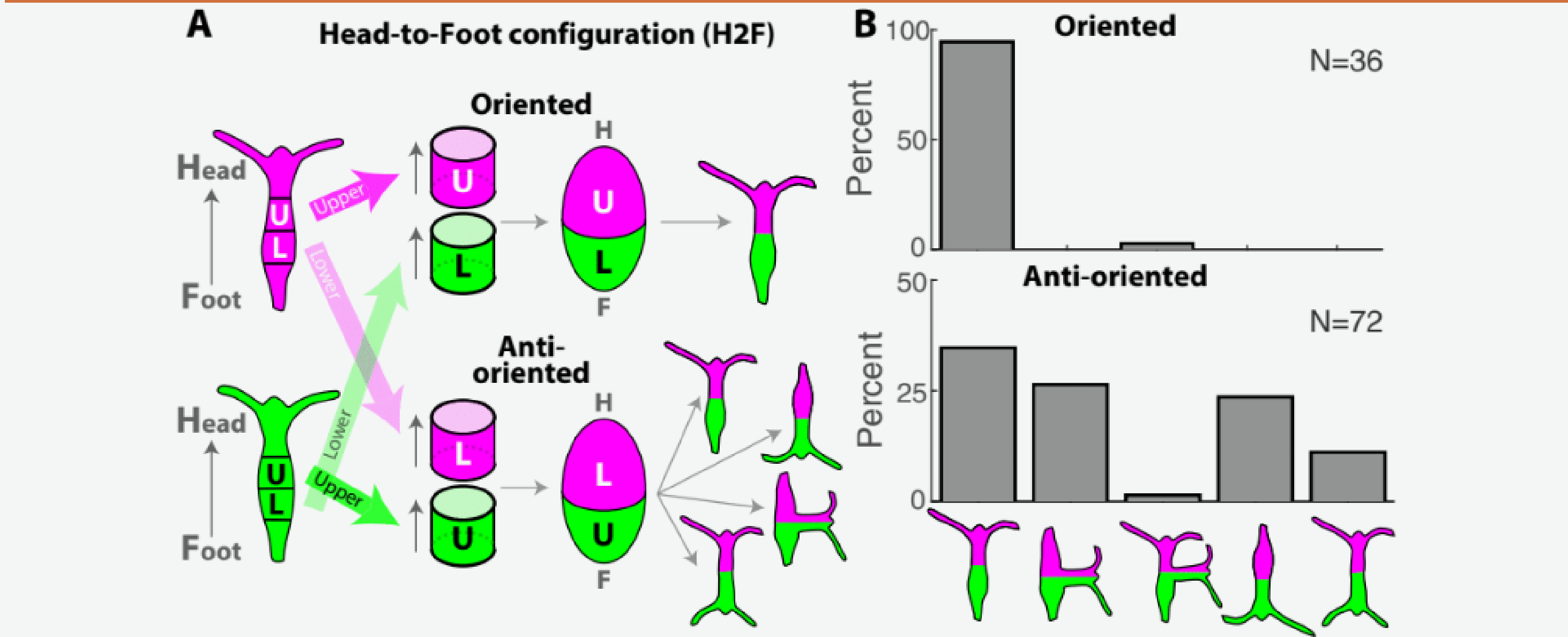


A graft creates a second peak, but the peak does not stay at the graft. It drifts to $2L/3$, a position selected by the model.

Source density is not needed to make a head — but the model, not the wound, decides where the head ends up.

3 Positional memory and source density

3.1 Grafting exposes missing information



Head-to-foot grafts, oriented vs. anti-oriented. Livshits et al. (2022). K. Keren group. Reversing the orientation of comparable tissue pieces changes the distribution of outcomes. Near the resting state, u and v alone do not distinguish an upper-body fragment from a lower-body one.

Which state variable records the original position and orientation of the grafted tissue?

3.2 Prescribed $\rho(x)$ as tissue competence

PROFILE PLACEHOLDER
oriented and anti-oriented piecewise $\rho(x)$

A fixed source-density profile encodes tissue origin before the activator is present and biases where a wound-triggered peak forms (source-gradient idea, Suzuki & Takagi 2011).

Source density can hold positional memory for a long time — without making the graft-selected peak truly stationary.

3.3 Dynamic source-density model

$$\begin{aligned}\partial_t u &= D_u \Delta u + \rho \frac{au^2}{v} - \mu_u u, \\ \partial_t v &= D_v \Delta v + b\rho u^2 - \mu_v v + p_v, \\ \tau \partial_t \rho &= D_\rho \Delta \rho + u - \rho.\end{aligned}$$

- $\rho(0, x)$ stores the grafted configuration,
- τ sets the lifetime of memory,
- D_ρ communicates positional information in space.

3.4 Dynamic ρ gives metastable memory

JULIA SIMULATION PLACEHOLDER
long-lived peak near the graft + peak position $x_{\max}(t)$

The inherited ρ profile anchors a peak near the graft on the fast $u-v$ time scale. As ρ relaxes, the peak drifts toward a position preferred by the activator–inhibitor subsystem.

3.5 Diffusion sets the spatial reach of memory

PARAMETER-SWEEP PLACEHOLDER
memory time versus D_ρ and τ

D_ρ too small: memory stays sharply localised. Intermediate: a usable gradient forms. Too large: spatial information is erased.

Take-home message

- 1. p_c is enough for a rest state, an activation threshold, and patterning.
- 2. The model selects head positions; wounds elsewhere give transient peaks.
- 3. ρ adds inherited positional information for grafted tissue.
- 4. Dynamic ρ gives metastability: long-lived anchoring, then slow reorganisation.

Source density is not needed to make a head.

It may be needed to remember where a head should form.

Outlook. A non-diffusing head-identity variable h with hysteresis could separate transient activator peaks from stable morphological commitment.